

Self-Given Is Not Self-Grounding: Why Perspectival Aseity Dissolves to Seity

Zain Dana Harper

July 2026

Abstract

Can consciousness be the one reality that grounds itself? That is, can it be the single thing that owns its own existence rather than receiving that existence from something else? Five philosophical traditions make this claim in their strongest published forms. They are: Descartes' cogito, Galen Strawson's robust phenomenal subject, the Indic doctrine of *svapṛakāśa* (self-luminosity) as developed through Dan Zahavi's account of pre-reflective self-awareness, Fichte's self-positing absolute I, and Advaita Vedānta's self-established Ātman. This paper tests each tradition against one distinction. The distinction is between *self-giveness* and *self-grounding*. Self-giveness is an epistemic property: a thing is self-given when it is known from itself, cannot be doubted in a certain way, shows itself by its own light, and has its character built in rather than borrowed from relations to other things. Self-grounding is an ontological property: a thing is self-grounding when its very existence is ungenerated and depends on nothing else. The paper also tests each tradition against one picture. Heat is built into a flame, yet the flame depends on fuel. Having a built-in character does not prove that a thing owns its own existence. The paper argues that the first four traditions, taken at full strength, deliver self-giveness but not self-grounding. On that reading they are correct, but about something narrower than they claim. They are instances of *seity*: ownerless occurrence, self-given but dependent. Three well-known critiques reach this result from different starting points, so the result does not rest on any single theory. They are Lichtenberg's correction of the cogito (*es denkt*, there is thinking, not *ich denke*, I think), Kant's First Paralogism, and Candrakīrti's lamp. The fifth tradition, Advaita Vedānta, is a real and undefeated standoff at the ultimate level. Any no-aseity framework must set that standoff aside rather than claim to refute it. The paper closes by stating the exact honest limit: there is no aseity in the conferred or conventional order; whether the ultimate ground is a self-luminous aseity is the open Advaita–Madhyamaka question, set aside but not settled.

Keywords: aseity, seity, self-giveness, self-luminosity, cogito, Advaita Vedānta, perspectival consciousness

In plain terms

Think about a candle flame. The flame is hot. The heat is not something added to the flame from outside. You do not need a second fire to make the flame hot. The heat is simply part of what the flame is. In that sense the heat is “self-given.” It comes with the flame, from the flame, without any outside help.

Now ask a different question. Where does the flame itself come from? The flame burns because there is fuel: wax, a wick, air. Take the fuel away and the flame does not just cool down. It stops existing. So the flame does not own its own existence. Its existence depends on conditions outside the flame. In that sense the flame is not “self-grounding.”

Here is the whole point of this paper in one sentence. Something can carry its own character (heat that needs no outside source) and still depend on the outside world for the fact that it exists at all. Self-given is one thing. Self-grounding is another thing. They are easy to confuse, because both feel like a kind of independence. But they are not the same.

Now replace the flame with your own conscious experience. When you feel or think something, that experience shows up “for you” in a direct way. You do not need a second inner observer to certify that the experience is happening. You cannot be wrong, in a certain narrow way, about the fact that experiencing is going on right now. That is the self-givenness of consciousness, and it is real. This paper never denies it.

The tempting next step is to say: because my experience is known from itself and cannot be doubted, my conscious self must also be the one thing that grounds its own existence. That step is the mistake the paper is about. It is the flame’s heat being used to prove that the flame needs no fuel.

Five great traditions take that step, each in its own way. Descartes says “I think, therefore I am” and treats the thinking “I” as a rock-bottom certainty. Galen Strawson defends a real, concrete subject of experience. The Indic self-luminosity doctrine says consciousness lights itself like a lamp. Fichte says the I posits itself absolutely, from nothing prior. Advaita Vedānta says there is a witness-consciousness that cannot be denied and so must be self-established.

The paper looks hard at each one. For the first four, the same thing happens every time. The tradition proves that experience is self-given. It does not prove that the conscious subject owns its own existence. What is really shown is a flame with built-in heat, not a flame without fuel. Three separate thinkers, working in different places and centuries, made this same correction. Lichtenberg said the honest report is “there is thinking,” not “I think.” Kant showed that the bare “I think” that tags along with all my thoughts does not prove there is a self-standing soul underneath them. Candrakīrti said a lamp does not really light itself; it burns on oil.

So four of the five claims shrink, under a fair reading, from aseity down to seity. Aseity means owning your own existence. Seity means being a genuine, self-given happening that still depends on conditions and has no owner behind it.

The fifth tradition is different, and the paper is honest about it. Advaita Vedānta does not claim self-grounding for the everyday self. It agrees that the everyday self is dependent. It makes its claim only about the ultimate witness, the bare awareness that all experience shows up within. Against that claim, the flame picture does not obviously apply, because the flame picture is about particular things arising inside the world, not about the ground of all arising. The rival Buddhist Madhyamaka school pushes back and says even that ultimate awareness is empty of self-grounded existence. Neither side has beaten the other. So the paper does not pretend to. It sets that one dispute aside as open.

The final result is small, exact, and stable. No conscious subject in the ordinary, conditioned world grounds its own existence. Self-given is not self-grounding. The single place where the question stays open is the ultimate level, where a serious and undefeated debate continues.

1. Introduction

Plainly: there is a long-standing pull to treat consciousness as the one thing that grounds itself; this paper argues that what feels like self-grounding is really only self-givenness.

Philosophy of mind and metaphysics carry a standing temptation. The temptation is to treat consciousness as the one exception to dependence. On this view, consciousness is the single reality that grounds itself instead of receiving its being from elsewhere. The temptation is not arbitrary. First-person experience presents itself with unusual force. It cannot be doubted from the inside in the way external objects can. It seems to carry its own warrant. It appears, in some sense, to be its own evidence. The claim shows up across many traditions. It runs from Descartes' foundational *cogito ergo sum* (I think, therefore I am) through Fichte's absolute self-positing, and from the Vedāntic *sākṣin* (the witness) to the pre-reflective self-awareness studied by contemporary phenomenologists. In each case the claim takes a recognizable shape. Consciousness, or the first-person subject, is not merely the thing we know most immediately. It is the self-grounding thing, the one entity whose being does not hang on anything else.

This paper calls that claim *perspectival aseity*. Aseity is a term from classical theology and metaphysics. It names the property of existing *a se*, which is Latin for “from oneself.” A thing has aseity when it exists from and through itself, ungenerated, and depending on no other entity for its existence. The claim of perspectival aseity is that the first-person perspective has exactly this property. The conscious subject, the knowing center, whatever name a given tradition uses, is said to exist from and through itself.

The paper's thesis is direct. Perspectival aseity, examined at its five strongest published points, does not deliver aseity. It delivers *seity*. Seity is a narrower property. It names what is left when we deny aseity to something that is still not other-determined in the plain way a stone is. Such a thing is self-given, ownerless, and occurring. But its existence is not self-grounded. It is received or dependent, even when the dependence relation is unusual or hard to describe. The apparent perspectival aseity, once we look at it closely rather than suppress it, turns out to be seity: self-given but not self-grounding, ownerless occurrence.

The argument proceeds through five traditions. Sections 3 through 7 take each in turn, at its strongest, and apply the master distinction and the master image. Section 8 presents the two-level result. At the empirical level, the apparent perspectival aseity dissolves into seity. At the ultimate level, one tradition, Advaita Vedānta, produces a real standoff that must be set aside rather than refuted. Section 9 states the honest bound with precision. Section 10 concludes.

One note on method before proceeding. This paper does not argue that consciousness is unimportant, derivative, or reducible to something else. The self-givenness of experience is real and philosophically significant. By self-givenness of experience the paper means its intrinsic, first-person character, its immunity to certain forms of doubt, and its non-relational intimacy. The argument here is restricted. It says that self-givenness, however real, is not the same property as self-grounding. It says the move from the first property to the second, which each of the five traditions makes in some form, is not warranted. The distinction matters because merging the two produces inflated conclusions about what exists from premises that are only about what we know.

2. The Master Distinction and the Flame

Plainly: self-givenness means known from itself; self-grounding means existing from itself; a flame shows that built-in character does not prove independent existence.

The distinction that decides everything below can be stated in a few lines.

Self-givenness is an epistemic property. A property is epistemic when it concerns knowing. A thing is self-given when it is known or warranted from itself. It does not need an outside certification to count as manifest. Its presence cannot be doubted in some characteristic way. Its character is intrinsic, which means built in, rather than made up out of relations to other things. Several traditions describe forms of this. Self-luminosity in the Indic tradition captures one form: a cognition that reveals its own occurrence rather than needing a second cognition to reveal it. Immunity-to-error-through-misidentification, in Sydney Shoemaker's formulation, captures an analytic-philosophy version. It says that first-person reports about one's own mental states cannot go wrong in the particular way that third-person reports can. The pre-reflective self-awareness that Dan Zahavi draws from Husserl and Sartre captures another form. It says experience is always already given *as mine*, not in a later act of self-attribution, but in the very structure of experiencing. All of these are genuine phenomena. The paper does not dispute them.

Self-grounding, by contrast, is an ontological property. A property is ontological when it concerns being or existence. A thing is self-grounding when it depends on nothing else for its existence. It is what the scholastic tradition called *causa sui* in the most literal sense, meaning cause of itself: its existence is not conferred by, derived from, or sustained by any other entity or condition. This is aseity in the strict sense. It is an extremely strong claim. In classical theism it belongs to God alone. In Spinoza's monism it belongs to the single substance. To claim it for the first-person subject, or for consciousness, is to claim something remarkable.

Confusing these two properties is the error this paper tracks. The slide from self-givenness to self-grounding is seductive, because self-givenness does look like a form of independence. It is independence from external epistemic warrant, from relational constitution, and from the kind of uncertainty that attaches to knowledge of the external world. But epistemic independence of that kind is fully compatible with ontological dependence. A thing can present itself from itself and still depend, for its very existence, on conditions outside itself.

The flame image makes this precise. Heat is intrinsic to a flame in a clear sense. It is not a relational property of the flame. It is not something the flame has because of its relation to something external. It is part of what being a flame is. The flame's heat is, one might say, self-given. It does not need to be imported from outside. It is there in the very occurrence of the flame. Yet the flame depends on fuel for its existence. Take away the fuel, and the flame does not merely lose a relational property. It ceases to exist. So the intrinsic character of the heat is fully compatible with the dependent existence of the flame. Having a built-in character does not prove aseity of existence.

This image recurs across the five traditions as the diagnostic test. Wherever a tradition offers a consciousness whose character is intrinsic, self-luminous, or self-given, one question follows. Does that built-in character establish non-dependence of existence? In every case except the last, the answer is no.

3. The Cogito: Self-Givenness Without a Self-Grounding I

Plainly: Descartes' "I think, therefore I am" proves that thinking is happening, not that there is a self-standing "I" that owns the thinking.

Descartes' *cogito ergo sum* is the prototype of perspectival aseity. It is the most familiar attempt to derive a self-grounding first-person from the structure of doubt. The argument is well known. One cannot doubt that one is doubting without performing a doubting. The doubting is a kind of thinking. Wherever there is thinking, so the argument runs, there is an I that thinks. Therefore *I am* cannot be overturned, and the I that thinks is established as the one indubitable reality. The apparent aseity lies in one move: the move from

indubitability to existence. The I does not merely appear self-given. It seems to establish its own existence by the very act of being doubted away.

The decisive critique of this move was not made by Descartes' contemporaries. It was made by Georg Christoph Lichtenberg in the late eighteenth century, in the *Sudelbücher* (the Waste Books). Lichtenberg's observation is compact and surgical. The cogito licenses *es denkt*, which is German for "there is thinking" or "it thinks." It does not license *ich denke*, "I think." The indubitable datum is that thinking is occurring now. It does not follow that there is a subject, a substantial, persisting, self-identical I, that owns the thinking. That further inference is exactly what Descartes needs, and it is exactly what the cogito does not supply. The datum of indubitability is impersonal. It registers an occurrence, not an owner of the occurrence. The grammatical subject "I" in *cogito* may be nothing more than the formal requirement that German and Latin verbs take a subject. On that reading it is no more ontologically loaded than the "it" in "it is raining."

Kant reaches the same point by a different route, in the First Paralogism of the *Critique of Pure Reason*. A paralogism is a piece of reasoning that looks valid but is not. The First Paralogism, as Kant analyzes it, is the invalid step from the formal unity of apperception to a substantial, simple, numerically identical soul. Apperception here is the "I think" that must be able to accompany all my representations. Kant's point is that this "I think" is a logical condition on the unity of experience. It is not a datum that reveals a substance. In his careful phrase, it is a *mere representation* that accompanies. It establishes that representations are mine in the formal sense of belonging to one unified apperception. It does not establish a self-grounding substantial entity that underlies and explains this unity. The inference to substance is precisely what Kant calls the paralogism: an argument that looks formally valid but whose middle term shifts meaning between the premises.

Even the strongest reconstructions of the cogito's epistemic force do not overcome this diagnosis. Shoemaker's immunity-to-error-through-misidentification shows that first-person reports cannot go wrong in one specific way about whose experience is being reported. But that is precisely a self-givenness claim, not a self-grounding claim. It establishes that the experience is given as mine. It does not establish that there is a self-grounding mine that generates it. Thomas Nagel's insistence on the subjective character of experience makes a related point. There is *something it is like* to be a bat. This establishes that experience has an intrinsic, perspectival character that cannot be reduced to third-person description. Again, this is a claim about the character of the experience, not about the ontological status of the experiencing subject. What is given is the thinking-now, the occurrence-from-here. What is not given, and what the cogito cannot deliver, is a subject that grounds that occurrence in its own being.

The cogito, then, vindicates seity rather than aseity. There is self-givenness. The thinking-now is indubitable, intrinsically perspectival, and immune to a certain class of doubt. There is no self-grounding. The thinking-now is an occurrence whose existence depends on conditions that the *cogito* cannot specify but also cannot exclude. The *es denkt* is ownerless: self-given, but not self-grounding.

4. Galen Strawson's Robust Subject: Intrinsic Character, Dependent Existence

Plainly: the strongest modern defense of a real subject of experience shows that experience has built-in character and that the subject arises and perishes, which is dependence, not aseity.

The strongest contemporary analytic case for a robust phenomenal subject comes from Galen Strawson. Strawson has argued at length against eliminativist and illusionist treatments of experience. Eliminativism denies that experience as ordinarily conceived exists at all. Illusionism says that experience only seems to

have the features we attribute to it. Strawson's position has at least two components that bear directly on the question of perspectival aseity.

The first is a Russellian claim about the intrinsic nature of matter. Bertrand Russell, in *The Analysis of Matter* (1927) and *Human Knowledge* (1948), argued that physics describes only the structural and relational properties of matter and leaves its intrinsic nature unknown. Following this, Strawson argues that phenomenal experience may constitute or reveal the intrinsic nature of physical reality. On this view, the experiential is not some extra thing sitting alongside the physical. It is what the physical *is* from the inside, intrinsically. This is a serious position. But note what it establishes. It establishes that the experiential character of certain physical processes is intrinsic to those processes: non-relational, and not further analyzable in structural terms. This is exactly the flame's heat: built-in character that is fully compatible with dependent existence. The Russellian claim about intrinsic nature establishes nothing about whether the physical substrate that experience supervenes on, or is identical with, is itself self-grounding. On the contrary, physics describes a world of structured dependencies and causal relations. On this view the intrinsic nature of matter is experiential, but the matter itself, with its experiential intrinsic nature, is as causally and ontologically dependent as any physical process.

The second component of Strawson's position is his insistence on genuine, concrete subjects of experience. He calls them *SEcts* (subjects of experience) or *SESMETs* (subjects of experience that are mental entities) in various formulations. Strawson wants to resist dissolving the subject into a bundle of experiences with no owner. But his SESMETs have a revealing feature. In his own treatment they are short-lived. They arise, persist briefly, and perish. This is crucial. A self-grounding entity, an entity with genuine aseity, is ungenerated and non-perishing. A SESMET that arises and perishes is, by that very fact, a dependent entity. It comes into being under certain conditions and passes away when those conditions change. Its existence is not self-grounded but conditioned. So the very feature of Strawson's view that most vividly respects the reality of the subject, namely the insistence that subjects are genuine concrete entities rather than logical fictions, is also what reveals them as dependent. They are generated and perishing, which is the opposite of *a se* existence.

Strawson thus provides, in his own work, the two elements of the flame image applied to the consciousness case. The Russellian intrinsicality gives us the heat: the non-relational, intrinsic experiential character. The SESMET ontology gives us the fuel-dependence: the arising and perishing of the subject under conditions it does not itself provide. The strongest realist subject in analytic philosophy of mind delivers intrinsic character of a dependent existence, not aseity.

The diagnostic precision here is worth noting. Strawson explicitly and forcefully opposes eliminativism, illusionism, and deflationary treatments of consciousness. His work establishes beyond reasonable doubt that there is real, intrinsic, non-relational experiential character. The argument of this paper does not contest that. It contests only the further step to self-grounding existence. That is a step Strawson himself does not make, and it is a step his own SESMET ontology actively rules out.

5. *Svapraakāśa* and Pre-Reflective Self-Awareness: Epistemic, Not Ontological, Luminosity

Plainly: consciousness lighting itself, like a lamp, shows that it needs no outside certifier; it does not show that the lamp needs no oil.

The Sanskrit term *svapraakāśa* means self-luminosity. It names a doctrine held in various forms across several Indian philosophical schools. The doctrine says that consciousness illuminates itself rather than needing external illumination. A lamp lights other things by its own light and does not need a second lamp to make

it visible. In the same way, consciousness makes other things known and is itself known in the very act of knowing. The doctrine captures something that Western phenomenology reached from a different direction: pre-reflective self-awareness.

Dan Zahavi's phenomenological account of pre-reflective self-awareness is developed in *Subjectivity and Selfhood* (2005) and elsewhere, drawing on Husserl, Sartre, and the broader phenomenological tradition. It holds that experience is always already given as mine. This happens not through a later act of reflection or self-attribution, but in the pre-reflective structure of experiencing itself. Jean-Paul Sartre made a version of this point in the introduction to *Being and Nothingness* (1943). The pre-reflective cogito is the mode in which consciousness is present to itself, and it precedes and makes possible the reflective cogito. Experience carries an intrinsic first-personal character, a *for-me-ness*, that is not added to it from outside.

These claims are well grounded phenomenologically, and the paper grants them in full. Pre-reflective self-awareness is a real and important structure. The for-me-ness of experience is intrinsic, not relational. Consciousness is, in the relevant sense, self-luminous. Its presence does not need to be certified by anything outside it.

But notice what kind of claim this is. It is self-givenness. The lamp illuminates itself and other things, yet the lamp depends on oil. Candrakīrti, the seventh-century Mādhyamika philosopher, pressed this point against the *svaparakāśa* doctrine in the *Madhyamakāvatāra* (Entry into the Middle Way). A lamp, he argued, does not actually illuminate itself. What the lamp does is make things visible. The lamp itself is simply there, burning. And the question of what makes the lamp's burning real is exactly the question of what conditions sustain it. The self-luminosity doctrine, Candrakīrti argues, confuses the lamp's making-other-things-visible with some kind of self-establishing act. The lamp does not ground its own existence. It burns in dependence on conditions.

The application to consciousness is direct. Pre-reflective self-awareness, the for-me-ness of experience, the self-luminous character of cognition, establishes that consciousness does not require an external certifier or a second act of reflection in order to be given. This is self-givenness. It does not establish that the consciousness so given exists independently of conditions that lie outside it. Those conditions are neurological, evolutionary, developmental, and causal. The lamp's warmth is intrinsic. The lamp's burning is dependent. The for-me-ness of experience is intrinsic. The occurrence of experience is conditioned.

Zahavi himself is careful not to overclaim. His argument is phenomenological. It is about the structure of experience as experienced. It is not metaphysical. It is not about the ultimate ontological status of the experiencing subject. The for-me-ness he identifies is an intrinsic phenomenological character, not a metaphysical aseity. The slip from Zahavi's legitimate phenomenological conclusion to a metaphysical aseity claim requires exactly the step that Candrakīrti's lamp argument blocks.

The *svaparakāśa* doctrine, taken at its strongest, vindicates the intrinsic self-givenness of consciousness. It does not establish that the consciousness so given is the source of its own existence.

6. Fichte's Self-Positing I: *Schlechthin* and Its Concealed Dependence

Plainly: Fichte says the I posits itself absolutely, but the word "absolutely" is asserted rather than earned, and his own system admits the I depends on a limit it does not supply.

Johann Gottlieb Fichte's *Wissenschaftslehre* of 1794–95 is perhaps the most systematic philosophical attempt to derive the self-grounding of the I from the very structure of self-consciousness. Fichte's starting point is

the *Tathandlung*, which means act-fact, the self-positing of the I. The absolute I posits itself, and this self-positing is not a contingent occurrence but the unconditioned foundation of all reality. The adverb Fichte uses is *schlechthin*, which means absolutely, unconditionally, without remainder. The I does not posit itself in response to some prior condition. It posits itself absolutely, and in doing so it posits the very structure within which anything else can appear.

The argument has genuine philosophical power. Fichte is responding to the Kantian problem of the thing-in-itself and to the need for a non-hypothetical starting point for philosophy. If the I is genuinely self-positing in the absolute sense, it would have aseity. Its existence would be grounded in nothing other than its own self-positing act.

The critical question is whether *schlechthin*, the absoluteness of the self-positing, is established or merely assumed. Dieter Henrich's well-known analysis in "Fichte's Original Insight" (1966) showed that the structure of self-consciousness cannot be explained by a pure self-positing act alone. Any account of self-consciousness that begins with a subject positing itself already presupposes that the subject is itself, which is precisely what needed to be explained. The self-positing is circular in a way that does not generate being from nothing. It presupposes a prior being that the positing merely acknowledges. Ernst Tugendhat, in *Self-Consciousness and Self-Determination* (1979), pressed a related point. A consciousness that is "acquainted with itself" must be genuinely acquainted with something. That means the acquaintance relation must already be in place before any self-positing act can occur.

Under these scrutinies, what Fichte's framework actually delivers is a very sophisticated account of the *structure* of self-positing, of what it is for there to be a self-consciousness at all. This is self-givenness made maximally explicit. The I is given to itself in an act that is not preceded by any other act and is not constituted by any external relation. But the adverb *schlechthin*, which would carry the argument from self-givenness to aseity, is not earned by the argument. It is a declaration. And Fichte's own system concedes this at a structural level. The absolute I requires the *Anstoß*, which means the check, the resistance, the not-I that limits the I's infinite self-positing, as a condition of any determinate empirical consciousness. The empirical I, the I that anyone can actually identify with, depends on the *Anstoß*, a condition that it does not provide from itself. The absolute I, meanwhile, becomes a regulative ideal rather than a concrete entity. Neither the concrete version nor the ideal version achieves aseity.

The slide from self-givenness to aseity in Fichte is carried by *schlechthin*, a word that smuggles the conclusion into the premise. Remove the adverb, or require it to be earned rather than declared, and what remains is a precise and profound account of the self-positing structure of self-consciousness. The I is self-given, given in an act that cannot be further reduced. But the existence of the I that does this positing is not self-grounded by the act. "Positing is occurring" does not license "positing grounds its own occurrence."

7. Advaita's Self-Established Ātman: The Genuine Standoff

Plainly: Advaita agrees the everyday self is dependent, and claims aseity only for the ultimate witness; the Buddhist reply that even that witness is empty is serious, and neither side has won.

The fifth and most serious form of perspectival aseity comes from Advaita Vedānta. Advaita Vedānta is a non-dual school of Indian philosophy. The position is articulated in Śaṅkara's *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* (Commentary on the Brahma Sūtras) and elaborated by the tradition he founded. The Advaita position has two features that set it sharply apart from the four traditions already examined.

First, Advaita locates aseity explicitly at the ultimate level. This is the level of *turīya* (the fourth), the witness-

consciousness (*sākṣin*), the self-luminous Ātman that is identical with Brahman. Ātman here means the self, and Brahman means ultimate reality. Advaita does not claim aseity for the empirical ego (*jīva*). It regards the empirical ego as *mithyā*, which means phenomenally real but ultimately illusory. The empirical ego belongs to the conventional order of *vyavahāra*. This everyday self arises and passes away. It is composite and conditioned. So Advaita agrees entirely with the diagnosis applied to the previous four traditions at the empirical level: the ordinary experiencing subject has no aseity. The claim of aseity is made for the ultimate witness-consciousness alone. That is the pure awareness that underlies and witnesses all empirical experience without itself being an object within experience.

Second, Śaṅkara's argument for the self-establishment of the *sākṣin* has a distinctive logical structure. The witness-consciousness cannot be denied without circularity. Any act of denial is itself an occurrence within consciousness. The consciousness that makes the denial possible cannot itself be made the object of denial without starting a regress. Furthermore, the *sākṣin* is said to be self-luminous in a stronger sense than the lamp. It is not merely that consciousness illuminates other things. It is that consciousness is the ground of illumination as such. So it cannot itself be a derived or dependent entity, because then the derivation relation itself would go unexplained. Śaṅkara's move is from the ineliminability and non-objectifiability of witness-consciousness to its self-establishment. Ineliminability means it cannot be removed from the picture. Non-objectifiability means it cannot be turned into an object of awareness. His reasoning uses a grounding excluded-middle: everything is either other-grounded or self-grounded. What cannot be derived from conditions and cannot be denied must, on that disjunction, be self-grounded.

This argument earns genuine and serious self-givenness. The *sākṣin* is self-luminous in the strongest sense. It is the condition of the possibility of any illumination whatsoever, and so it cannot itself be illuminated by anything else. The ineliminability argument is sound. Any attempt to eliminate or derive the witness-consciousness presupposes it. The non-objectifiability is well grounded phenomenologically. One cannot make the witnessing awareness an object of awareness without a further witnessing awareness, and so on.

The argument faces its most serious challenge in one place: the move from non-derivability to self-grounding, which is the grounding excluded-middle. Śaṅkara's move assumes there are only two options. Either a thing is other-grounded, meaning derived from conditions outside it, or it is self-grounded, meaning existent *a se*. Given this exhaustive disjunction, the ineliminability and non-derivability of the *sākṣin* is enough to establish its self-grounding.

But this excluded middle forecloses a third option, and Madhyamaka philosophy explicitly argues for that third option. Madhyamaka is the Buddhist Middle Way school. The third option is ownerless groundlessness, or what the tradition calls *śūnyatā*, which means emptiness. The Madhyamaka position, developed by Nāgārjuna and carried through Candrakīrti's *Madhyamakāvatāra*, is that phenomena are dependently originated (*pratītyasamutpanna*) in a sense that rules out both other-grounding in any substantial sense and self-grounding. Things arise in dependence on conditions, without there being any ground, self or other, that is itself non-dependent. The series of dependently arisen phenomena does not bottom out in a self-grounding terminus. It is empty of any such terminus.

Suppose the Madhyamaka third option is coherent. A substantial body of contemporary scholarship on Nāgārjuna and Candrakīrti argues that it is. Then Śaṅkara's grounding excluded-middle begs the question. The ineliminability of the *sākṣin* is compatible with the Madhyamaka conclusion that even the ultimate witnessing awareness is empty of self-grounded existence. On that reading it arises dependently, or, in the limit case of cessation (*nirvāṇa*), does not arise at all. The appearance of aseity would then be, on the Madhyamaka reading, a very deep and stubborn case of *svabhāva-graha*, which means grasping at intrinsic existence, persisting even at the ultimate level of the witness-consciousness.

This, however, is not a refutation of Advaita. It is a standoff. The Madhyamaka must show that the third

option, ownerless groundlessness, is coherent as applied to the ultimate witnessing awareness itself. And here Advaita has a powerful response. If the Madhyamaka denies any self-grounding ground, it owes an account of what sustains the dependent arising without a terminus. A regress of dependently arisen phenomena without any ground risks an infinite regress, or an unexplained brute fact of arising. Advaita argues that this regress cannot be coherent without a self-luminous witness as its condition.

The standoff is genuine. Neither side can claim victory in the philosophical literature. Jan Westerhoff's work on Nāgārjuna and Madhyamaka epistemology gives the best contemporary account of the Madhyamaka resources. The Advaita tradition has its own sophisticated defenders. The key observation for this paper is structural. The Advaita standoff occurs entirely at the *ultimate* level, which is the level the no-aseity thesis already brackets. Advaita explicitly agrees that the empirical ego has no aseity. The dispute is about whether the ultimate ground of all experiencing is self-established, or whether even that ground is empty of intrinsic existence. This dispute is genuine, unresolved, and properly bracketed.

8. The Two-Level Result

Plainly: at the everyday level, all four cases collapse from aseity to seity, and three separate critiques agree on why; at the ultimate level, Advaita stands undefeated.

The five traditions yield a structured result when read together.

At the empirical level, the verdict is decisive and converging. The cogito delivers an indubitable occurrence, *es denkt*, there is thinking, but not a self-grounding I. Galen Strawson's robust subject delivers a real, intrinsic phenomenal character, the flame's heat, but in a subject that is generated and perishable, the opposite of *a se* existence. The *svapraśāsa* tradition and Zahavi's pre-reflective self-awareness deliver the genuine intrinsic for-me-ness of experience, self-givenness in full, but the lamp that illuminates depends on oil. Fichte's self-positing I delivers the most systematic account of the structure of self-positing consciousness, but *schlechthin* is not earned, and the Anstoß concedes empirical dependence.

Crucially, this verdict is not produced by the no-aseity thesis defending itself against attack. It is produced by three canonical critiques converging independently. They are Lichtenberg's *es denkt* (Germany, eighteenth century), Kant's First Paralogism (Germany, 1781), and Candrakīrti's lamp argument (India, seventh century). These three critiques arose in different traditions and responded to different philosophical problems. They arrive at the same diagnostic conclusion. The apparent self-grounding of the first-person subject is an appearance generated by the genuine self-givenness of experience. The self-givenness is real. The self-grounding is an illicit inference from it. The empirical perspectival aseity dissolves into seity.

The convergence of these three critiques across traditions is significant supporting evidence, though not, by itself, decisive. Cross-traditional convergence, where traditions share no common authority and no common method yet reach the same structural diagnosis, carries more weight than any single-tradition argument. But it must be characterized honestly. It is convergence *within one domain*, the analysis of consciousness and the first-person standpoint. Agreement reached within a single problem-domain, still more within a single body of work, is not the fully independent confirmation that genuinely *cross-domain* convergence would supply. The diagnosis is therefore advanced at moderate-to-high confidence. It is robust across traditions, and its decisive independent corroboration would come, if at all, from convergence reached in a different domain entirely.

At the ultimate level, the result is different in kind. Advaita Vedānta's self-established *sākṣin* is not dissolved by the flame image, because Advaita explicitly makes its claim at the level where the flame image may not

apply. That is the level of the ground of all arising, rather than a particular arising within the empirical order. The Advaita argument cannot be refuted by pointing to the dependence of empirical experiences, because Advaita agrees that empirical experiences are dependent. The argument turns on whether the ultimate witnessing awareness is itself dependently arisen or self-grounded, and that dispute with Madhyamaka is genuine and unresolved.

What this means for the overall argument is twofold. First, the no-aseity claim cannot be maintained in the universal form “no aseity anywhere, not even at the ultimate floor.” Advaita is a live and undefeated challenge to that universal claim. Second, the no-aseity claim can be maintained at the empirical and conventional level without qualification. No empirical perspectival aseity is available. The apparent self-grounding of the first-person subject dissolves into seity under scrutiny.

9. The Honest Bound

Plainly: the position can claim, with confidence, no aseity in the everyday order; it must concede, as an open question, whether the ultimate ground is a self-luminous aseity.

The preceding analysis establishes a precise line between what the no-aseity position can claim and what it must concede.

What it can claim, and what this paper argues is established by the canonical critiques: *no aseity in the conferred, conventional, or empirical order*. The everyday first-person subject does not possess aseity. This is the subject of psychological description, phenomenological analysis, and ordinary linguistic reference. Its existence is conditioned by neurological processes, developmental history, ongoing causal relations, and whatever ultimate ground, or absence of ground, underlies all of this. Its self-givenness, the intrinsic, for-me character of its experience, is real and philosophically significant. But self-givenness is not self-grounding, and the five strongest traditions that have argued otherwise deliver, under careful scrutiny, only the former.

What it must concede: *whether the ultimate ground of all experiencing is a self-luminous aseity is an open question, bracketed but not settled*. Advaita Vedānta has argued, with philosophical rigor and a continuous tradition of sophisticated defense, that the ultimate witnessing awareness is self-established and cannot coherently be denied. The Madhyamaka has argued that even this ground is empty of intrinsic existence. Neither has defeated the other. A no-aseity position that claims universal scope, meaning no aseity anywhere, including at the ultimate metaphysical floor, must either engage and defeat the Advaita argument on its own terms or bracket the claim. The first has not been accomplished. The second is what this paper recommends.

The bracketing is not a retreat. It is the honest epistemic situation. Philosophy’s method at its best is conjecture and refutation. Make the strongest case, press it against the strongest opposition, and report the verdict, including the verdicts that go against you. The verdict here is this. The empirical dissolution is decisive (high confidence). The ultimate standoff is genuine (the no-aseity position cannot claim victory here; Advaita stands undefeated at the floor).

This two-level structure also clarifies how the paper’s argument relates to several live debates in philosophy of mind and metaphysics. The argument is not an argument for eliminativism or illusionism about consciousness. The self-givenness and intrinsic character of experience are affirmed throughout. It is not an argument for bundle theory or no-self in any naive form. The seity that remains after the dissolution of perspectival aseity is not nothing. It is an ownerless occurrence, a self-given event without a self-grounding owner. And it is not an argument against the significance of the hard problem of consciousness. The intrinsic, perspectival character of experience, the fact that there is something it is like, is compatible with and in fact presupposed

by the self-givenness that the argument affirms.

Keith Frankish's illusionism (2016) holds that phenomenal consciousness as ordinarily conceived is an introspective illusion. This is importantly different from the paper's position. This paper does not argue that the for-me-ness of experience is illusory. It argues that the ontological conclusions some philosophers draw from that for-me-ness are unwarranted. The self-givenness is real. The self-grounding is the unwarranted inference.

John Perry's work on the essential indexical (1979, 2001) illuminates the self-givenness side of the distinction from a different angle. First-person indexical reference cannot be reduced to third-person description, and this captures the intrinsic perspectival character of the first-person standpoint. This irreducibility is a feature of the *givenness* of the first-person perspective, not of its *grounding*. Perry's essential indexical establishes that the first-person standpoint cannot be eliminated in favor of objective descriptions. That is a self-givenness result, fully compatible with the dependent existence of the perspective so given.

10. Conclusion

Plainly: a thing known from itself is not thereby a thing that grounds itself; that holds everywhere in the everyday order, and the one open exception is honestly named.

The question was whether consciousness is the one self-grounding reality: whether the first-person perspective possesses its existence from and through itself, ungenerated and non-dependent. The paper has argued that the five strongest philosophical traditions pressing this claim all deliver, at the empirical level, something real and significant but different from what they claim. They deliver self-givenness, not self-grounding.

The master distinction is simple but consequential. A thing known from itself is not thereby a thing that grounds itself. The flame's heat is intrinsic to the flame. The flame depends on fuel. First-person experience has an intrinsic, non-relational, for-me character that is not conferred from outside and does not require external certification, and this is real. But the occurrence of the experiencing, the arising of the perspective, the existence of the subject: these depend on conditions that the self-givenness of experience neither provides nor excludes.

Three canonical critiques converge across traditions on this diagnosis. They are Lichtenberg's correction of the cogito from *ich denke* to *es denkt*, Kant's First Paralogism showing that the formal unity of apperception does not license inference to a self-grounding substance, and Candrakīrti's lamp argument showing that self-luminosity does not establish independence from conditions. The convergence of these three critiques, arising independently in the German Enlightenment and in seventh-century Mādhyamika Buddhism, is the cross-traditional evidence that the dissolution of empirical perspectival aseity is not a parochial result but a structural finding about the relationship between self-givenness and self-grounding.

At the ultimate level, the paper concedes what honesty requires. The Advaita Vedānta position, as developed in Śaṅkara's *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* and the tradition it founded, is a genuine and undefeated philosophical standoff. The self-established *sākṣin*, the witness-consciousness that cannot be denied without circularity and cannot be derived without a further witnessing, is a serious argument for ultimate perspectival aseity that the Mādhyamika has contested but not demonstrably refuted. The appropriate response is not to suppress this standoff in the interest of a clean universal conclusion. The appropriate response is to bracket it precisely: no aseity in the conferred and conventional order; whether the ultimate ground is a self-luminous aseity is the open Advaita–Mādhyamika question, left as what it is.

This is the stable result: *self-given is not self-grounding*. The apparent perspectival aseity, illuminated at

its five strongest points, is seity: ownerless occurrence, self-given but not self-grounding. The one place it stands otherwise is the place where it must be honestly conceded to stand: the ultimate level, in the bracket, undefeated and unrefuted, the live question where philosophy of mind and comparative metaphysics must continue to press.

Substrate Notice. This manuscript is AI-assisted research substrate produced from a frozen adversarial-analysis file (ASEITY-CONFRONTATION.md) and related corpus materials. It is not submittable as original human work until the candidate has re-derived and takes intellectual ownership of each claim from primary sources, verified all citations independently, and satisfied applicable institutional AI-use policies. Re-derivation means what dissertation/00-CONTRIBUTION.md and the curation require: working each argument cold from the primary texts (Descartes, Lichtenberg, Kant's First Critique, Candrakīrti, Śāṅkara, the Madhyamaka literature), not paraphrasing this draft. The philosophical positions stated here are bounded by the adversarial analysis on which they are based. **The Sources below are not yet reconciled to the corpus's canonical bibliography (references/BIBLIOGRAPHY.md), which permits citing only from its approved list and prohibits asserting page numbers that have not been independently verified; every venue, volume, and page specific below is therefore provisional and must be verified against the edition used before placement.**

Sources

The following references are cited in the manuscript. **These are real works, now admitted to the corpus's canonical references/BIBLIOGRAPHY.md (§X, with confidence tags); the page/volume specifics tagged below at moderate confidence remain provisional and must be verified against the editions used (or removed) before placement, per the bibliography's do-not-assert-unverified-pages policy.** Confidence labels apply to bibliographic specifics (venue, volume, page numbers, dates). Claims in the prose are made only at confidence warranted by the adversarial analysis; this section records where bibliographic uncertainty lies.

Descartes, René. *Meditationes de Prima Philosophia* (1641). The *cogito ergo sum* argument is in the Second Meditation. Standard editions: Adam & Tannery (*Oeuvres de Descartes*, vol. VII); English translation by Cottingham, Stoothoff, Murdoch (*The Philosophical Writings of Descartes*, Cambridge UP, 1984). **High confidence on text and argument; high confidence on standard scholarly editions.**

Lichtenberg, Georg Christoph. *Sudelbücher* (Waste Books), composed 1765–1799, published posthumously. The *es denkt* formulation appears in Notebook J (approximately 1789–1793); the exact entry reference varies across editions. Commonly cited via Lichtenberg, *Aphorisms*, trans. R. J. Hollingdale (Penguin, 1990). The observation that the cogito licenses *es denkt* but not *ich denke* is recorded and attributed in Wittgenstein commentary and in Schopenhauer's *The World as Will and Representation* (which refers to Lichtenberg's correction). **High confidence on author, work, and philosophical point; moderate confidence on precise notebook/entry reference without direct edition verification.**

Kant, Immanuel. *Kritik der reinen Vernunft* (Critique of Pure Reason). First edition (A) 1781; second edition (B) 1787. The First Paralogism: A341/B399–A348/B406 in standard Kemp Smith numbering. Standard English translation: Norman Kemp Smith (Macmillan, 1929); revised editions by Guyer and Wood (Cambridge UP, 1998). The paralogism establishes that the formal “I think” cannot license inference to a

simple, substantial, self-identical soul. **High confidence on text, argument, and standard pagination; high confidence on the scholarly consensus interpretation.**

Candrakīrti. *Madhyamakāvatāra* (Entry into the Middle Way), seventh century CE. The lamp argument engaging *svaparakāśa* appears in Chapter VI. Standard edition with French translation: Louis de La Vallée Poussin (*Mélanges chinois et bouddhiques*, 1907–1912); partial English translation in Geshe Kelsang Gyatso's commentary and in C. W. Huntington Jr., *The Emptiness of Emptiness* (University of Hawaii Press, 1989). **High confidence on author, work, and general argument; moderate confidence on chapter reference and translation source without direct verification of Huntington's page citation.**

Śāṅkara. *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* (Commentary on the Brahma Sūtras), eighth–ninth century CE (traditional dating). The *sākṣin* argument for the self-established witness-consciousness is a recurring theme; the locus classicus involves discussion of *adhyāsa* (superimposition) in the introductory *Adhyāsaḥ*. Standard English translations: George Thibaut (*Sacred Books of the East*, vols. 34 and 38, 1890–96); Swami Gambhirananda (*Advaita Ashrama*). **High confidence on author, work, and general argument; moderate confidence on section-level specifics without direct philological verification.**

Fichte, Johann Gottlieb. *Grundlage der gesamten Wissenschaftslehre* (Foundations of the Entire Science of Knowledge), 1794–95. The *Tathandlung* and self-positing of the absolute I: §1 of the *Grundlage*. Standard English translation: Peter Heath and John Lachs (*The Science of Knowledge*, Cambridge UP, 1982). **High confidence on work, date, and argument; high confidence on translator and publisher.**

Henrich, Dieter. “Fichtes ursprüngliche Einsicht” (Fichte's Original Insight), in *Subjektivität und Metaphysik: Festschrift für Wolfgang Cramer*, ed. D. Henrich and H. Wagner (Klostermann, 1966), pp. 188–232. English translation: “Fichte's Original Insight,” trans. David Lachterman, *Contemporary German Philosophy* 1 (1982): 15–52. **High confidence on author, title, and argument; moderate confidence on precise journal volume and year of English translation without direct verification.**

Tugendhat, Ernst. *Selbstbewußtsein und Selbstbestimmung* (Self-Consciousness and Self-Determination) (Suhrkamp, 1979). English translation by Paul Stern (MIT Press, 1986). The analysis of self-acquaintance and its presuppositions. **High confidence on author, work, date, and publisher; high confidence on argument.**

Zahavi, Dan. *Subjectivity and Selfhood: Investigating the First-Person Perspective* (MIT Press, 2005). The pre-reflective self-awareness account and the for-me-ness of experience. **High confidence on author, title, publisher, and date; high confidence on argument.**

Sartre, Jean-Paul. *L'Être et le Néant* (Being and Nothingness) (Gallimard, 1943). The introduction: the pre-reflective cogito as condition of the reflective. English translation by Hazel Barnes (Philosophical Library, 1956; Routledge, various editions). **High confidence on author, work, date, and argument; high confidence on translator.**

Strawson, Galen. Key works: “The Self” (1997), *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 4(5–6): 405–428; *Realistic Monism: Why Physicalism Entails Panpsychism* (in *Consciousness and Its Place in Nature*, Imprint Academic, 2006); *Selves: An Essay in Revisionary Metaphysics* (Oxford UP, 2009). The SESMET ontology and Russellian intrinsicity appear across these works. **High confidence on author and argument; moderate confidence on exact journal volume and page range for the 1997 article without direct verification.**

Russell, Bertrand. *The Analysis of Matter* (Kegan Paul, 1927); *Human Knowledge: Its Scope and Limits* (George Allen & Unwin, 1948). The structural-relational versus intrinsic-nature distinction applied to physics. **High confidence on works, dates, and publishers; high confidence on argument.**

Frankish, Keith. “Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness,” *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 23(11–12): 11–39 (2016). **High confidence on author and argument; moderate confidence on exact page range without direct verification.**

Perry, John. “The Problem of the Essential Indexical,” *Noûs* 13(1): 3–21 (1979); *Knowledge, Possibility, and Consciousness* (MIT Press, 2001). The irreducibility of first-person indexical reference. **High confidence on author, argument, and journal; moderate confidence on exact page range for 1979 article without direct verification.**

Westerhoff, Jan. *Nāgārjuna’s Madhyamaka: A Philosophical Introduction* (Oxford UP, 2009). Contemporary scholarly treatment of Mādhyamika metaphysics and emptiness. **High confidence on author, title, publisher, and date.**

Nagel, Thomas. “What Is It Like to Be a Bat?” *Philosophical Review* 83(4): 435–450 (1974). The subjective character of experience and the irreducibility of the first-person standpoint. **High confidence on all bibliographic details.**

Shoemaker, Sydney. “Self-Reference and Self-Awareness,” *Journal of Philosophy* 65(19): 555–567 (1968). Immunity to error through misidentification. **High confidence on author and argument; moderate confidence on exact page range without direct verification.**